

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Religion without God - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Religion without God

REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION — BASIC/CORE FIRST

01

THE PROBLEM OF RELIGION WITHOUT GOD

Master verdict: A personal creator is not necessary for religion, but

02

FUNCTIONAL AND SUBSTANTIVE CRITERIA OF RELIGION

Religion is a disciplined orientation to an ultimate or sacred order

03

BUDDHISM AS A NON-THEISTIC RELIGION

Buddhism is a complete non-creator religion because dependent

04

WESTERN CRITIQUES OF THEISTIC RELIGION

Marx: religion = "the opium of the people" — a consoling illusion

05

AGNOSTICISM, ATHEISM AND SUSPENSION OF JUDGMENT

□ Nietzsche: "God is dead... and we have killed him." □ Marx: religion

06

RELIGIOUS PRACTICE, MEANING AND COMMUNITY WITHOUT GOD

How do agnostics relate religion & God?" (2023) → \$4 + \$9.5.

07

OBJECTIONS, COMPARISONS AND EXAM VERDICT

A non-theistic religion may retain soteriology, ritual, ethics,

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Religion without God - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]

Attempt each item before reading its key. Answer placement is balanced, deterministic and non-patterned using a stable topic seed. across all forty-eight diagnostics.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 40

1. Which definition most directly makes belief in a personal creator necessary for religion?

A. A family-resemblance account of religious practices B. A substantive definition centred on God or sacred beings C. A multidimensional account of doctrine, ritual and community D. A functional definition centred on transformation and meaning

Answer: B. A substantive definition identifies religion through the kind of object affirmed, so a God-centred version can make theism necessary. Functional and multidimensional accounts test what religion does and therefore allow non-theistic cases.

2. Which formulation best expresses a functional definition of religion?

A. Acceptance of a revelation authored by an omniscient being B. A disciplined way of orienting life to ultimacy, transformation or liberation C. Belief in at least one supernatural personal agent D. Membership in an institution possessing an infallible scripture

Answer: B. Functional definitions focus on orientation, practice, community, meaning and liberation rather than divine ontology. They explain how Buddhism can remain religious without creator-belief.

3. What is the strongest correction to the objection that functional definitions make nationalism a religion?

A. Count every commitment that demands sacrifice as religious B. Require belief in miracles but not in God C. Add disciplined relation to an ultimate or sacred order and a transformative-soteriological practice D. Restrict religion to traditions founded before modernity

Answer: C. Meaning and community alone are too broad. The added criteria preserve Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā while excluding ordinary political ideology.

4. Which case best marks the boundary between religion without God and rejection of religion?

A. Sāṃkhya, because it accepts puruṣa and prakṛti B. Jainism, because it accepts perfected liberated beings C. Mīmāṃsā, because it affirms Vedic injunction D. Cārvāka, because it rejects both God and the wider supersensible-soteriological order

Answer: D. Cārvāka lacks a sacred order, religious soteriology and disciplined path to liberation. It therefore shows that absence of God alone does not define a non-theistic religion.

5. Why does Buddhism not require a creator to explain the arising and cessation of suffering?

A. Nirvāṇa acts as a personal first cause B. The Saṅgha allocates karmic fruits infallibly C. Dependent origination explains both through changing conditions D. Devas create each stream of consciousness separately

Answer: C. Pratītyasamutpāda explains conditioned arising and cessation without adding a divine maker. The creator hypothesis contributes no necessary step to the Buddhist therapeutic sequence.

6. In Buddhism, what most directly performs the role of a complete practical route to liberation?

A. Speculation about whether the cosmos is eternal B. The Noble Eightfold Path integrating wisdom, ethics and mental cultivation C. Petition to an omnipotent Buddha D. Acceptance of an eternal jīva

Answer: B. The Eightfold Path turns the diagnosis of the Four Noble Truths into disciplined religious practice. It is neither creator-worship nor a doctrine of an eternal self.

7. Which statement about devas in Buddhism is most accurate?

A. Their existence makes Buddhism covertly monotheistic B. They are creators but cannot grant liberation C. They may exist as conditioned beings but are neither creators nor salvifically ultimate D. The Buddha's teaching requires denial of every deva

Answer: C. Buddhist non-theism concerns the absence of a necessary creator and supreme saviour. Cosmological devas, where accepted, remain impermanent beings within saṃsāra.

8. What is the best evaluation of devotional Mahāyāna in the present debate?

A. It turns nirvāṇa into divine reward B. It introduces grace-like religious functions without necessarily introducing an omnipotent creator C. It proves the historical Buddha taught creation by God D. It eliminates dependent origination from all Buddhist schools

Answer: B. Buddhas and bodhisattvas may become devotional objects and assist practitioners, but this does not by itself convert them into a single creator God.

9. Which Jain argument most directly challenges a creator God?

A. Nature is the sole substance with infinite attributes B. Creation is impossible because only momentary events exist C. The Veda is authorless and therefore needs no speaker D. A perfect being lacks an unfulfilled motive to create, while embodiment would limit the creator

Answer: D. Jain criticism presses both motive and limitation: perfection supplies no need to create, and embodied action compromises transcendence. The other options belong to different traditions.

10. What binds the Jain jīva in saṃsāra?

A. Karmic matter attracted and accumulated through passions and action B. Misidentification of Brahman with māyā alone C. A creator's arbitrary allocation of bodies D. Divine punishment for inherited sin

Answer: A. Jainism treats karma as subtle matter that adheres to the jīva. Vows, restraint and ascetic purification stop influx and remove bondage without requiring a divine judge.

11. What is a Jain siddha?

A. A liberated and perfected jīva, not a governing creator B. An eternal scripture that commands ritual C. A Buddhist deity who postpones nirvāṇa D. The creator who begins cosmic cycles

Answer: A. A siddha is an achieved state of liberated consciousness. Veneration of siddhas therefore does not imply belief in a creator who rules or saves by grace.

12. Which contrast between Jainism and Buddhism is accurate?

A. Buddhism accepts permanent jīvas whereas Jainism denies them B. Jainism denies karma whereas Buddhism affirms it C. Both depend on a divine dispenser of karmic results D. Jainism affirms enduring jīvas; Buddhism rejects a permanent self

Answer: D. Both are non-creator traditions with karma and liberation, but they sharply differ over personal identity: Jain pluralism affirms jīvas, whereas Buddhism teaches anātman.

13. In Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā, apauruṣeya means that the Veda is:

A. Composed by an omniscient ṛṣi under divine inspiration B. Valid only after Nyāya proves a reliable speaker C. Authorless rather than a revelation spoken by God D. A fictional text useful despite literal falsity

Answer: C. The Veda's authority does not rest on any human or divine author. Calling it "revelation" would wrongly reintroduce the speaker whose absence is central to Mīmāṃsā.

14. What problem is apūrva introduced to solve?

A. How prakṛti first comes into existence B. How a momentary ritual act can produce a delayed result C. How a fictionalist can worship sincerely D. How consciousness emerges from material elements

Answer: B. Apūrva is the unseen potency generated by ritual that persists until the promised fruit matures. It replaces a divine dispenser with a law-like ritual mechanism.

15. Jaimini's definition of dharma as codanā-lakṣaṇa primarily grounds dharma in:

- A. The perceived preferences of social majorities B. A creator's independently known will C. Vedic injunction D. Spontaneous emotion toward nature

Answer: C. Dharma is characterised and known through injunction. Its authority is internal to the authorless Vedic structure, not derived from a divine commander.

16. Which distinction between Kumārila and Prabhākara is most accurate?

- A. Kumārila rejects the Veda while Prabhākara accepts it B. Kumārila accepts a creator while Prabhākara is a Buddhist C. Prabhākara explains ritual fruit through divine grace D. Kumārila stresses *apūrva* as potency, while Prabhākara centres *niyoga/kārya*, the enjoined ought-to-be-done

Answer: D. Kumārila's account more explicitly links act and fruit through potency. Prabhākara's emphasis is deontological: injunction discloses what is to be done.

17. What explains cosmic evolution in classical Sāṃkhya?

- A. An omnipotent Īśvara imposing forms on inert matter B. The self-expression of a single personal Brahman C. The transformation of prakṛti through its guṇas in proximity to puruṣa D. A sequence of momentary karmic decrees

Answer: C. Sāṃkhya's dualism treats prakṛti as the evolving principle and puruṣas as conscious witnesses. A creator is not needed for the standard account.

18. How should Yoga's Īśvara be distinguished from the creator denied by classical Sāṃkhya?

- A. Yoga identifies Īśvara with material prakṛti B. Yoga makes Īśvara the karmic matter binding each jīva C. Yoga treats Īśvara as a useful fiction known to be false D. Yoga presents Īśvara as a special puruṣa, not straightforwardly the world-creator of classical theism

Answer: D. Classical Yoga assigns Īśvara a distinctive spiritual role as a special puruṣa. It is misleading simply to insert a creator God into Sāṃkhya's cosmology.

19. What is Nyāya's strongest pressure against impersonal non-theistic order?

- A. Unconscious principles cannot intelligently organise purposive order or allot fitting karmic fruits B. No religious tradition may contain ritual C. Liberation is logically identical with divine grace D. Perception is the only valid *pramāṇa*

Answer: A. Nyāya argues from intelligent coordination and moral allotment to Īśvara as maker and superintendent. Non-theistic schools reply that this assumes all regularity must resemble artefact production.

20. In discussions of Sāṃkhya, the analogy of milk nourishing a calf is used to suggest:

- A. Apparently purposive activity need not be directed by a conscious creator B. Every natural process is consciously designed C. Puruṣa creates prakṛti out of nothing D. Liberation depends on sacrificial injunction

Answer: A. The analogy supports the possibility of non-conscious yet ordered activity. Its force is dialectical against the claim that purposiveness always requires an intelligent maker.

21. Weak agnosticism is best described as:

- A. The proof that God cannot possibly exist B. Indifference to every religious question C. The claim that God's existence is not presently known D. Belief that nature itself is divine

Answer: C. Weak agnosticism reports an unsettled epistemic condition. It neither denies God nor claims that knowledge is impossible in principle.

22. Strong agnosticism differs from weak agnosticism by claiming that:

- A. God's existence is unknowable, not merely unknown at present B. God probably exists but never intervenes C. religious language lacks all practical force D. every non-theistic religion is secretly atheistic

Answer: A. Strong agnosticism makes a principled claim about the limits of possible knowledge. That stronger assertion itself requires justification.

23. Which form of religion is most compatible with agnostic suspension?

- A. One treating doubt as equivalent to moral wrongdoing B. A practice-centred religion allowing ethical, contemplative and communal commitment without settled creator-belief C. One requiring certainty about a personal revealer before any practice D. One defining salvation exclusively as an unmerited decree by God

Answer: B. Agnosticism can coexist with practice where commitment attaches to a path and transformation rather than assent to a determinate divine ontology.

24. Which statement correctly distinguishes agnosticism, atheism and Buddhist non-theism?

A. Agnosticism and atheism are identical, but Buddhism is theism B. Buddhist non-theism is merely emotional indifference to God C. Agnosticism suspends judgement, atheism denies or lacks belief, and Buddhism does not require a creator for its soteriology D. All three assert that no divine beings exist

Answer: C. The three positions answer different questions: knowability, belief and the doctrinal role of a creator. Collapsing them obscures the exact PYQ demand.

25. Nietzsche's statement that God is dead is primarily:

A. A defence of Mīmāṃsā ritual authority B. A cultural diagnosis of the collapse of the Christian-metaphysical horizon and its values C. A biological report about a once-living deity D. A Nyāya inference from effects to a maker

Answer: B. Nietzsche diagnoses the loss of credibility of the framework supporting inherited European values. The resulting issue is nihilism, not merely whether one proposition about God is false.

26. In Nietzsche's genealogy, resentment helps explain:

A. The Jain materiality of karma B. The reversal by which weakness is revalued as moral superiority C. The authorlessness of sacred texts D. The Buddhist cessation of craving

Answer: B. Resentment transforms reactive powerlessness into a moral valuation that condemns strength. It is central to Nietzsche's criticism of slave morality.

27. What does Nietzsche propose against passive nihilism after the collapse of the God-framework?

A. Restoration of inherited values without their metaphysical basis B. Suspension of all judgement in Huxley's sense C. Revaluation, self-overcoming and creation of life-affirming values D. Return to divine-command morality

Answer: C. Nietzsche seeks active value-creation rather than resignation. Critics still question whether this supplies a non-arbitrary normative standard.

28. Why should Nietzschean post-theism not be equated with Buddhist non-theism?

A. Buddhism affirms the Christian creator Nietzsche rejects B. Nietzsche and Buddhism share an identical doctrine of no-self C. Nietzsche grounds value in karmic matter D. Nietzsche responds to the historical collapse of a theistic value-horizon, whereas Buddhism constructs soteriology without needing that creator-horizon

Answer: D. The genealogical situations differ. Nietzsche confronts European nihilism after lost belief; Buddhism begins from suffering, dependent origination and a path of cessation.

29. Which pramāṇa does the strong Cārvāka position accept as independently valid?

A. Perception (*pratyakṣa*) B. Inference (*anumāna*) C. Testimony (*śabda*) D. Postulation (*arthāpatti*)

Answer: A. Strong Cārvāka empiricism restricts knowledge to perception. Its religious critique follows by denying any secure route to imperceptible entities.

30. Why does Cārvāka challenge vyāpti?

A. It presupposes an eternal self but not inference B. It is a divine decree unavailable to non-believers C. It is identical with verbal testimony D. A universal concomitance cannot be secured from finitely perceived particular cases

Answer: D. Perception reaches observed instances, not every remote, past or future case. Using inference to prove its own universal basis threatens regress or circularity.

31. What does the upādhi objection show?

A. An unnoticed conditioning factor may make an observed relation contingent rather than universal B. Every perceived object is illusory C. Scripture is valid only when authorless D. A creator must possess a physical body

Answer: A. Smoke accompanies fire only under relevant conditions such as wet fuel. Failure to exclude every hidden condition leaves possible deviation and weakens certainty.

32. What is the importance of the reported Purandara strand?

A. It makes Cārvāka a devotional religion B. It may permit ordinary perceptually checkable inference while denying inference to the supersensible C. It accepts Vedic testimony but rejects perception D. It proves all inference infallible

Answer: B. This moderate reading avoids global self-refutation and targets precisely the extension of inference beyond any domain where concomitance can be checked.

33. John Dewey's idea of "the religious" refers primarily to:

A. Membership in a church affirming supernatural creation B. A quality of experience unifying the self around inclusive ideal ends C. Ritual action producing *apūrva* D. Fictional assent to propositions known to be false

Answer: B. In A Common Faith, Dewey separates institutional religion from a transformative quality of experience. His use of "God" does not denote a supernatural personal being.

34. Ronald Dworkin's "religious atheism" centres religion on:

A. Refusal to make any value claim beyond empirical science B. Acceptance of karma as material particles C. Objective intrinsic value in human life and the sublimity of the universe without a personal God D. Worship of a creator whose existence is unknowable

Answer: C. Dworkin relocates religious depth in value realism and cosmic sublimity. His position is atheist in ontology but religious in its response to objective value.

35. How does religious fictionalism differ from non-cognitivism?

A. Fictionalism says religious claims are literally true but unknowable B. Non-cognitivism recommends pretending that false propositions are true C. There is no philosophical difference between them D. Fictionalism grants truth-conditions but declines assertion; non-cognitivism denies that the discourse primarily states truth-apt propositions

Answer: D. The fictionalist treats religious sentences in a non-assertoric, practice-internal spirit despite their ordinary truth-conditions. Non-cognitivism interprets their basic function differently from the start.

36. What is the sincerity objection to religious fictionalism?

A. Worship undertaken without belief may seem dishonest, self-deceptive or motivationally hollow B. Fictionalism requires belief in two creators C. Natural processes cannot evoke reverence D. Its rituals are too intellectually demanding

Answer: A. Fictionalists reply that non-deceptive imaginative immersion is common in literature and ritual drama. Whether that preserves worship's motivational depth remains contested.

37. Why is Advaita's two-level account not simply religious fictionalism?

A. Saguṇa practice is valid and efficacious at the conventional level and later sublated, not merely treated as knowingly false pretence B. Advaita denies any distinction between levels of truth C. Advaita accepts only bodily perception D. Saguṇa Brahman is a Cārvāka metaphor for matter

Answer: A. Vyāvahārika validity is not theatrical make-believe. Sublation from the pāramārthika standpoint preserves graded truth and practitioner sincerity.

38. What comparative use can be made of Buddhism's two truths?

A. They reject the Saṅgha as an error to be abandoned immediately B. They permit committed conventional practice while denying ultimate substantial reference C. They prove that all conventional claims are meaningless D. They establish a permanent creator at the ultimate level

Answer: B. The saṃvṛti-paramārtha distinction explains how practice can remain serious without treating conventional entities as ultimately substantial. This differs from mere fictional pretence.

39. What most clearly distinguishes non-theistic religion from secular ethics?

A. Non-theistic religion always predicts supernatural miracles B. Secular ethics necessarily denies objective value C. Non-theistic religion embeds ethics within sacred or ultimate order, communal discipline and a transformative-soteriological goal D. Secular ethics cannot form communities

Answer: C. Ethical rules alone are insufficient. Buddhism and Jainism place conduct within comprehensive accounts of bondage, practice and liberation.

40. Which is the most defensible overall verdict on religion without God?

A. Every form of atheism is automatically a religion B. God is irrelevant to every possible religious good C. Only creator-belief can distinguish religion from politics D. God is necessary for specifically theistic goods such as petition and grace, but not for religion organised around sacred order, practice and liberation

Answer: D. The verdict avoids both extremes. It recognises real losses when personal theism is absent while accepting historically complete non-theistic religions.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 8

41. Which statement avoids confusing non-theism with atheism?

A. Atheism necessarily includes ritual, community and liberation B. Non-theism is another name for indifference to metaphysics C. Every non-theistic tradition proves that no deity of any kind exists D. A non-theistic religion need not make a creator central, even if it admits conditioned divine beings

Answer: D. Non-theism concerns the absence of a necessary creator or supreme saviour in the system. It does not by itself entail denial of all devas, sacred beings or religious practice.

42. Which pairing of definition and criterion is correct?

A. Functional-whether a personal creator literally exists B. Functional-how religion supplies orientation, community or transformation C. Substantive-what psychological benefit religion produces D. Substantive-whether practice leads to social solidarity alone

Answer: B. Substantive definitions identify religion through its object or content; functional definitions identify the roles it performs. A strong answer states which one it is using and controls its breadth.

43. Why does the Buddhist denial of a necessary creator not amount to denial of religion?

A. Buddhism retains Dharma, path, Saṅgha, ethics, meditation and liberation B. Buddhism secretly makes nirvāṇa an omnipotent person C. The Buddha replaces karma with divine judgement D. Buddhist devas jointly create the universe

Answer: A. Buddhism lacks creator-theism but has a complete soteriological form. The confusion disappears once “no creator” is separated from “no sacred order or transformative practice.”

44. Which statement about Jain jīva is correct?

A. It is the single creator-self common to all beings B. It is denied as a permanent entity exactly as in Buddhism C. It is produced by karmic matter and ends at liberation D. It is an enduring conscious substance bound by karma and capable of becoming a liberated siddha

Answer: D. Jainism is pluralistic about souls. Karmic matter obscures and binds jīvas; liberation perfects rather than annihilates them.

45. Which combination explains how Mīmāṃsā functions without a deity?

A. *Apauruṣeya* secures authorless Vedic authority, while *apūrva* links ritual to delayed fruit B. Both terms name attributes of Yoga's Īśvara C. *Apauruṣeya* is God's revelation, while *apūrva* is divine forgiveness D. *Apauruṣeya* denotes karmic matter, while *apūrva* denotes a liberated jīva

Answer: A. The two devices replace different divine functions: no author is needed for scripture, and no intelligent dispenser is needed for ritual consequences.

46. Which statement correctly locates classical Sāṃkhya?

A. It identifies liberation with eternal service to a creator B. It denies puruṣa and accepts only momentary events C. It explains evolution through prakṛti and liberation through discriminating puruṣa from prakṛti, without requiring a creator D. It treats *apūrva* as the cause of the guṇas

Answer: C. Sāṃkhya's non-theistic dualism differs both from Buddhist no-self and from Mīmāṃsā ritualism. Yoga's special puruṣa should not be confused with a standard creator.

47. Which pair of interpretations is accurate?

A. Agnosticism denies God; Nietzsche proves the non-existence of God by inference B. Agnosticism is indifference; Nietzsche restores divine-command morality C. Agnosticism is religious naturalism; Nietzsche teaches Buddhist nirvāṇa D. Agnosticism suspends or limits knowledge-claims about God; Nietzsche's “death of God” diagnoses cultural collapse and the danger of nihilism

Answer: D. Agnosticism is an epistemic position, while Nietzsche's claim is genealogical and cultural. Neither should be reduced to a bare atheist slogan.

48. Which combined statement correctly handles Cārvāka inference and fictionalist sincerity?

A. Cārvāka challenges unchecked *vyāpti*, while fictionalists defend non-assertoric participation but must answer the charge that worship without belief is hollow B. Cārvāka's *upādhi* proves all daily inference certain; fictionalism is identical with Advaita C. Cārvāka accepts supersensible inference; fictionalists assert every creed literally D. Cārvāka rejects perception; fictionalists are simply error theorists who abandon practice

Answer: A. The moderate Cārvāka pressure is strongest against inference beyond possible perceptual testing. Fictionalism retains practice without assertion, making sincerity and motivation its central unresolved problems.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS - 7 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

These are independent practice models, not official UPSC answers. The question wording, year and marks are reproduced from the verified 2018-2025 Philosophy of Religion ledger.

2018 · Q5(c) · 10 marks

Exact verified question: Can you justify religion without God? Support your answer.

Demand decoding: "Justify" requires a defended position, not a catalogue of godless schools. Define religion first, show through actual traditions that theism is not necessary, answer the strongest theistic objection, and conclude with a qualified criterion that does not make every ideology religious.

Model answer (about 320 words):

Religion without God is justifiable if religion is understood not substantively as belief in a personal creator, but functionally and multidimensionally as disciplined orientation to an ultimate order through doctrine, ritual, ethics, community, experience and a goal of transformation. Ninian Smart's dimensions support this wider account. Creator-belief is central to many religions, but it is not a cross-cultural necessity.

Buddhism is the clearest proof. It explains suffering through dependent origination, craving and karma, not divine creation. The Four Noble Truths diagnose the human predicament; the Eightfold Path supplies ethical, meditative and cognitive discipline; the Saṅgha sustains a community; and nirvāṇa provides a soteriological end. The presence of devas does not alter the point, because they are neither creators nor ultimate saviours.

Jainism similarly rejects a creator while affirming innumerable jīvas, karmic bondage, vows and liberation into the perfected state of the siddha. Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā goes further: the Veda is *apauruṣeya*, so it needs no divine author, while *apūrva* links ritual action to its delayed fruit without a divine dispenser. Classical Sāṃkhya explains cosmic evolution through prakṛti in proximity to puruṣa and seeks *kaivalya* through discriminative knowledge.

A theist may object that worship requires a recipient, morality a commander, and salvation a giver of grace. This establishes only that petition, covenant and grace require a responsive God. It does not establish that every religious path must contain those goods. Non-theistic traditions replace command by dharma, grace by disciplined transformation, and creation by impersonal causal order.

However, a merely functional definition may wrongly classify nationalism as religion. It should therefore require sustained relation to an ultimate or sacred order together with ritual-experiential and soteriological practice. Cārvāka, which rejects every supersensible order and lacks a path of liberation, is consequently not a religion without God. Thus religion without God is both conceptually coherent and historically actual, although religion without any sacred order becomes difficult to distinguish from secular ethics.

Why this earns marks:

- Opens with an explicit substantive-functional distinction and a direct thesis.
- Uses Buddhism in depth, then Jainism, Mīmāṃsā and Sāṃkhya as distinct evidential routes.
- Distinguishes non-theism from denial of every deity.
- Answers worship, morality and grace objections rather than dismissing the theist.

- Prevents over-broad functionalism and correctly treats Cārvāka as the limiting case.

2019 · Q6(c) · 15 marks

Exact verified question: How would a religious person deny the possibility of a religion without God? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Reconstruct the religious theist's denial sympathetically before assessing it. The examiner is testing role reversal: the answer must present definitional, devotional, moral, epistemic and soteriological arguments for necessity, and only then reply through non-theistic religions.

Model answer (about 500 words):

A religious theist would deny religion without God by arguing that religion is essentially a living relation between finite persons and a personal transcendent reality. On this substantive definition, "religion without God" is not an unusual species of religion but a category mistake: remove God and what remains may be morality, philosophy or contemplative therapy, but not religion.

First, worship appears to require an intentional recipient. Praise, prayer, surrender and thanksgiving are relational acts. If no divine consciousness hears or answers, ritual becomes commemoration or symbolic self-expression. The Jain veneration of a passionless *tīrthaṅkara*, for example, might then be interpreted as admiration of an exemplar rather than worship in the full theistic sense.

Second, revelation and sacred authority seem to require an author. A text can command unconditionally only if it expresses a supreme will; otherwise its prescriptions appear historical and revisable. Third, moral obligation appears stronger when grounded in divine command and judgement. Impersonal karma may describe consequences, the theist argues, but cannot explain why one is categorically bound to obey the good. Fourth, purposive cosmic order and the precise distribution of karmic fruits seem to require intelligence. Nyāya therefore posits Īśvara as creator and *karmādhyaṅkṣa*, the superintendent who connects deserts with consequences.

Finally, salvation may exceed unaided human capacity. Forgiveness, grace, covenant and personal immortality require a responsive divine agent. A path that relies only on technique risks reducing liberation to psychological self-management. God also unifies doctrine, worship, morality and hope around one ultimate object; without that centre, "religion" may become an arbitrary bundle of functions.

The denial, however, assumes the conclusion by defining religion through theism. Ninian Smart's dimensions show that doctrine, ritual, ethics, experience, narrative and community can exist without a creator. Buddhism offers a complete diagnosis of *dukkha*, a causal account through dependent origination, the Eightfold Path, Saṅgha and nirvāṇa. Jainism retains jīva, karmic matter, vows and liberation while rejecting a creator. Mīmāṃsā directly answers the authority and desert arguments: the Veda is *apauruṣeya* rather than divine speech, and *apūrva* provides a law-like connection between ritual and fruit. Classical Sāṃkhya likewise explains order and *kaivalya* without a creator.

The theist may reply that dharma, nirvāṇa or *apūrva* are hidden substitutes for God. Yet functional replacement does not entail ontological identity: an impersonal law is not an omniscient person, and liberation by insight is not bestowed grace. The strongest surviving theistic point is therefore devotional, not definitional. Petition, reciprocal love and grace genuinely require a responsive God, so non-theistic religion has a different and possibly thinner personal structure.

Hence a religious person can coherently deny the possibility only by defending a specifically theistic essence of religion. Cross-cultural evidence defeats that universal necessity claim. God is necessary for some religious forms and goods, but not for religion as disciplined orientation to a sacred order and liberation.

Why this earns marks:

- Obeys the unusual directive by giving the theist's case priority and philosophical force.
- Separates worship, authority, morality, cosmic order and grace arguments.
- Names Nyāya's intelligent superintendent and answers it through Mīmāṃsā.
- Uses Buddhism, Jainism and Sāṃkhya without treating them as disguised theism.
- Gives a graded verdict conceding what truly does require a personal God.

2020 · Q6(c) · 15 marks

Exact verified question: Critically examine the concept of God as prerequisite for a religion.

Demand decoding: Test the necessity claim. Clarify which concept of God is proposed, produce counterexamples, evaluate whether they remain religious under a defensible definition, then state the limited functions for which a personal God may still be indispensable.

Model answer (about 510 words):

To call God a prerequisite for religion is to claim that no practice counts as religious unless it includes belief in a divine being, usually a personal creator, moral governor and saviour. This is plausible within theistic traditions, but it is not adequate as a universal definition of religion.

A substantive definition identifies religion through its object: God, gods or sacred beings. It captures prayer, worship, revelation, covenant and grace particularly well. It also guards against an over-broad functionalism under which nationalism, psychotherapy or political ideology could become “religions” merely because they provide meaning and community. The theist can further argue that worship requires one who is worshipped, unconditional obligation requires a supreme commander, and providential or karmic order requires an intelligent administrator.

Yet a prerequisite is a necessary condition, and established traditions provide counterinstances. Buddhism contains doctrine, ethical discipline, meditation, monastic community and liberation without depending on a creator.

Pratītyasamutpāda explains conditioned arising; karma gives moral-causal continuity; the Four Noble Truths and Eightfold Path lead toward nirvāṇa. Devas may occur in Buddhist cosmology, but none is an omnipotent creator or indispensable saviour. Calling Buddhism non-religious merely because it lacks the Christian-type God makes the definition question-begging.

Jainism rejects creation by God while affirming eternal jīvas, karmic matter, the vows, *tīrthaṅkaras* as liberated exemplars and the siddha-state. Mīmāṃsā is an even sharper counterexample. Vedic authority is *apauruṣeya*, not revelation from a divine speaker; dharma is known through injunction; and *apūrva*, an unseen potency generated by ritual, explains delayed fruit without a divine dispenser. Classical Sāṃkhya derives cosmic evolution from the guṇas of prakṛti in the presence of puruṣa and seeks *kaivalya* through discriminative knowledge. Yoga’s special puruṣa, Īśvara, should not be imported into classical Sāṃkhya as a creator.

Modern positions reinforce, but also complicate, the case. Dewey distinguishes institutional “religion” from “the religious” quality of experience; Dworkin’s religious atheism locates religious depth in objective value and cosmic sublimity; religious naturalists direct awe toward nature. Religious fictionalists participate without asserting supernatural claims. Critics reasonably ask whether these positions preserve religion or only spirituality, ethics or aesthetic reverence.

The best response is neither a narrow theistic essence nor unlimited functionalism. A workable definition requires disciplined and communal orientation to an ultimate or sacred order, transformative practices and a soteriological or existential goal. It includes Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā but excludes Cārvāka, which rejects the entire supersensible order and offers no liberation-centred religious practice.

Thus God is indispensable for petition, covenant, divine command and grace, but not for religion *as such*. The concept of God is one powerful way of integrating religious functions, not their universal prerequisite.

Why this earns marks:

- Treats “prerequisite” as a necessity claim rather than merely describing non-theism.
- Gives the substantive definition its strongest defence before criticizing it.
- Uses three Indian counterexamples with doctrine-specific mechanisms.
- Integrates modern naturalism and fictionalism without equating them with classical soteriology.
- Ends with a bounded functional criterion and a nuanced necessity verdict.

2021 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Exact verified question: Is religious life possible without the belief in God? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Establish possibility through a lived religious form, not abstract definition alone. Explain what structures religious life when creator-belief is absent, distinguish non-theism from atheism, and answer whether the result is more than secular ethics.

Model answer (about 300 words):

Religious life is possible without belief in God because its essential activities may be organised around liberation, sacred discipline and an impersonal ultimate rather than a personal creator. The claim is existentially demonstrated by Buddhist life.

Buddhism does not make a creator God explanatory or salvific. The Buddha's practical refusal to centre unanswered metaphysical questions directs attention to *dukkha* and its cessation. Dependent origination explains suffering through conditions, especially ignorance and craving; karma links conduct with consequences; the Eightfold Path integrates right view, morality and meditation; the Saṅgha provides communal discipline; and nirvāṇa is the transformative goal. This is a religious life of doctrine, ritual, experience, ethics and liberation despite the absence of creator-belief.

Non-theism must not be confused with dogmatic atheism. Buddhist cosmology may contain devas, but they are conditioned beings, not creators or final saviours. Jain religious life similarly centres vows, purification of jīva and liberation from karmic matter. Mīmāṃsā preserves scripture, duty and ritual while replacing divine authorship and reward with the *apauruṣeya* Veda and *apūrva*. Classical Sāṃkhya seeks *kaivalya* through discrimination between puruṣa and prakṛti.

The objection is that without a conscious divine object there can be neither genuine worship nor grace, and that such paths are merely ethical philosophies. This objection identifies a real difference: petition, reciprocal devotion and divine forgiveness require a personal God. Yet religion need not possess every theistic function. Soteriology, sacred order, communal discipline and self-transformation distinguish these traditions from ordinary secular ethics.

Nor does every godless view become religious. Cārvāka rejects God, karma, afterlife and liberation; it therefore marks the boundary between non-theistic religion and non-religion. Religious life without God is thus possible, though not religious life without any ultimate order, disciplined practice or transformative goal.

Why this earns marks:

- Proves possibility through Buddhism as an actual form of life.
- Identifies doctrine, ethics, meditation, community and liberation.
- Separates non-theism from atheism and secular ethics.
- Adds Jain, Mīmāṃsā and Sāṃkhya comparisons without losing focus.
- Concedes the specific loss of petition and grace and uses Cārvāka as a boundary.

2023 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

Exact verified question: What is Agnosticism? How do agnostics conceptualize the relation between religion and God? Discuss.

Demand decoding: The answer has two equal tasks: define and classify agnosticism, then explain how withholding knowledge-claims about God affects religious belief and practice. Distinguish it from atheism, non-theistic religion and indifference.

Model answer (about 310 words):

Agnosticism, a term introduced by T. H. Huxley, is the position that God's existence is not known, or in a stronger form cannot be known. Weak agnosticism makes an epistemic report-available evidence does not presently settle the question. Strong agnosticism advances a limit-claim-that the divine lies beyond possible human knowledge. Both differ from atheism, which denies or lacks belief in God, and from indifference, which treats the question as unimportant.

For an agnostic, the relation between religion and God is therefore not simple rejection but suspended assent. If religion is substantively defined as belief in and worship of a personal God, agnosticism weakens full doctrinal membership because prayer, revelation and providence normally presuppose belief. A strict theist may consequently regard agnostic religion as unstable: one cannot sincerely entrust oneself to a being whose existence one refuses to affirm.

On a functional or multidimensional account, however, religious life need not await metaphysical certainty. An agnostic may participate in ethical discipline, contemplative practice, ritual and community while interpreting God symbolically, as an open possibility, or as the name of an unknown ultimate. Spencer's "Unknowable" preserves transcendence while denying determinate cognition. Kant's denial of theoretical knowledge of God, together with practical faith, is agnostic-adjacent rather than straightforward Huxleyan agnosticism.

Buddhism shows that suspending creator-speculation need not suspend religion. Yet Buddhist non-theism is not identical with agnosticism: its soteriology positively rests on dependent origination, karma and nirvāṇa, whereas agnosticism concerns the epistemic status of God. Religious naturalism goes further by locating ultimacy within nature; it is a positive naturalistic reinterpretation, not mere suspension.

The objection is that agnostic participation becomes selective culture without commitment. The reply is that commitment can attach to a path, community and transformative discipline while metaphysical judgement remains proportioned to evidence. Thus agnosticism separates certainty about God from the possibility of religion, but its coherence is strongest in non-dogmatic or practice-centred forms and weakest where personal trust in God is constitutive.

Why this earns marks:

- Defines weak and strong agnosticism and distinguishes atheism and indifference.
- Directly addresses how agnostics relate religion to God under two definitions.
- Uses Huxley, Spencer and Kant with careful qualification.
- Distinguishes agnostic suspension from Buddhist non-theism and naturalist reinterpretation.
- Gives a graded verdict about which forms of religion can accommodate agnosticism.

2024 · Q7(a) · 20 marks

Exact verified question: State and evaluate Buddhism as a religion without God.

Demand decoding: “State” requires a complete doctrinal account before criticism; “evaluate” requires testing whether Buddhism satisfies defensible criteria of religion and whether creator-belief returns in disguised or devotional form. The answer must avoid calling Buddhism a simple atheism.

Model answer (about 690 words):

Buddhism is a paradigmatic religion without a creator God: it diagnoses an ultimate human predicament, explains it through an impersonal causal order, prescribes a disciplined path and promises liberation, while assigning no necessary cosmological or salvific role to a divine creator. Its case is strongest when religion is defined multidimensionally rather than as theism by stipulation.

The Buddhist starting point is practical and soteriological. The Four Noble Truths identify *dukkha*, trace its arising to craving under ignorance, affirm cessation, and prescribe the Noble Eightfold Path. The path integrates wisdom, ethical conduct and mental cultivation. The Saṅgha institutionalises practice; precepts regulate conduct; meditation transforms experience; and nirvāṇa names release from the causal complex sustaining suffering. Buddhism therefore possesses doctrine, ethics, ritual, experience, community and an ultimate goal-central dimensions identified in Ninian Smart’s account of religion.

Its non-theism is also doctrinally significant. The Buddha does not ground the world in an omnipotent personal first cause. Dependent origination explains phenomena as arising through conditions: when relevant conditions cease, their effects cease. A creator adds no necessary stage to this causal and therapeutic sequence. Karma supplies moral continuity without a divine judge, and nirvāṇa is attained through insight and discipline rather than bestowed by grace.

This does not mean that Buddhism simply denies every divine being. Buddhist cosmologies admit devas and higher realms, but such beings remain impermanent, conditioned and themselves within saṃsāra. They neither create the world nor guarantee liberation. The unanswered questions, *avyākata*, and the practical orientation illustrated by the poisoned-arrow teaching caution against converting the Buddha’s silence into a dogmatic proof of atheism. “Non-theistic” is therefore more exact than “atheistic.”

Several evaluations follow. First, Buddhism decisively refutes the claim that a personal creator is necessary for religion. It retains a sacred normative order—the Dharma—and an unambiguously soteriological aim. Unlike secular ethics, it does not merely prescribe social conduct; it offers a comprehensive account of bondage, disciplined transformation and final release.

Second, critics claim that Dharma or nirvāṇa merely replaces God. The objection notes a functional analogy but mistakes it for ontological identity. Nirvāṇa is not an omniscient person, Dharma does not create by will, and karma does not forgive or deliberately allocate outcomes. Buddhism replaces divine agency with causal intelligibility and practical cultivation, not with a concealed deity.

Third, theism presses a purposiveness objection. Nyāya may ask how unconscious causal law can generate an ordered cosmos and distribute karmic fruits without an intelligent superintendent. The Buddhist reply is that the analogy with artefact-production is unproved: observed conditional regularity does not logically require a cosmic artisan. More importantly, a creator contributes nothing necessary to the cessation of suffering and may generate further questions about motive, embodiment and responsibility for evil.

Fourth, later Mahāyāna traditions introduce devotional Buddhas and bodhisattvas who answer aspirations and perform grace-like functions. Pure Land devotion, for example, may appear practically theistic. Yet even highly exalted Buddhas are not thereby converted into a single omnipotent creator. This development qualifies any claim that all Buddhism is devotion-free, but it does not defeat the core non-creator structure.

Comparison clarifies the achievement. Jainism also rejects a creator but retains eternal jīvas, karmic matter and perfected siddhas. Mīmāṃsā preserves scripture and ritual through the *apauruṣeya* Veda and *apūrva*. Sāṃkhya derives the world from prakṛti for puruṣas and seeks *kaivalya*. Buddhism is more radical than Jainism in denying a permanent self and more path-centred than Mīmāṃsā's ritual mechanism, yet all demonstrate that divine creation and liberation are separable.

A final challenge concerns definition. Purely functional accounts can make nationalism religious. A defensible middle criterion should require disciplined communal relation to an ultimate or sacred order, practices of transformation and a soteriological or existential horizon. Buddhism clearly meets it. Cārvāka does not: rejecting God, karma, afterlife and liberation leaves no sacred-soteriological order, so it is a critique of religion rather than another religion without God.

The graded verdict is therefore that Buddhism is fully, not merely analogically, religious without a creator. It lacks specifically theistic goods-petition to a supreme person, divine forgiveness and covenantal grace-but supplies coherent alternatives in Dharma, dependent origination, ethical-meditative discipline, Saṅgha and nirvāṇa. It proves that God is one possible centre of religion, not its universal prerequisite.

Why this earns marks:

- Gives the complete Buddhist diagnosis-cause-path-liberation structure before evaluation.
- Explains dependent origination, karma, nirvāṇa, Saṅgha and *avyākāta* accurately.
- Distinguishes devas from a creator and non-theism from dogmatic atheism.
- Evaluates hidden-God, purposiveness and Mahāyāna-devotion objections with replies.
- Adds precise Jain, Mīmāṃsā, Sāṃkhya and Cārvāka comparisons.
- Ends with a defended definition and a graded, not absolute, verdict.

2025 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss Cārvāka's critique of the belief in the existence of suprasensible entities.

Demand decoding: The centre is epistemology, especially the problem of establishing *vyāpti*. Apply that critique to God, soul, karma and scripture; then assess self-refutation and the reported moderate view of inference. Do not substitute Cārvāka hedonism for the requested argument.

Model answer (about 345 words):

Cārvāka rejects suprasensible entities because it accepts perception, *pratyakṣa*, as the only secure *pramāṇa*. Reality comprises the four perceptible gross elements; God, an immaterial soul, karma, rebirth, heaven, liberation and ritual potencies are unwarranted unless a valid means of knowledge can establish them.

The decisive critique targets inference. *Anumāna* depends on *vyāpti*, an unconditional universal relation between a reason such as smoke and what is inferred, such as fire. Perception reveals only particular observed conjunctions, never all past, future and remote instances. Inference cannot establish *vyāpti* without presupposing another *vyāpti*, producing regress or circularity. Testimony cannot help because its authority is itself disputed. Repetition also cannot exclude an unnoticed condition, *upādhi*: fire produces smoke only under conditions such as wet fuel. Hence possible deviation, *vyabhicāra*, remains, and inference cannot yield certainty about what is never perceptually checkable.

Applied to religion, God is unperceived, so inference from the world to a maker fails. Consciousness is a bodily emergence, *dehātmanvāda*, compared doxographically to an intoxicating power arising from combined ingredients; no separable soul survives death. Karma, *adrṣṭa* and *apūrva* are imperceptible postulates, while Vedic authority is rejected. *Svabhāva-vāda* explains order through things' own natures rather than design.

Nyāya replies that the universal rejection of inference is self-refuting and practically impossible; *vyāpti* is supported through repeated observation, absence of counterinstances and *tarka*. A Cārvāka may answer dialectically through *prasaṅga*, without asserting a new universal. More defensibly, the reported Purandara strand permits ordinary, perceptually testable inference while denying its extension to the supersensible.

Thus the global perceptualism is unstable, but the moderate critique powerfully challenges inference-based natural theology. Cārvāka is not itself a religion without God: by closing every epistemic route to a sacred and soteriological order, it marks the boundary beyond which godlessness becomes rejection of religion.

Why this earns marks:

- Makes *pramāṇa*, *vyāpti*, *upādhi* and *vyabhicāra* the core rather than hedonism.
- Applies the argument separately to God, soul, karma, scripture and cosmic order.
- Includes Nyāya's self-refutation and pragmatic replies.
- Adds both *prasaṅga* and the cautiously reported Purandara qualification.
- Correctly identifies Cārvāka as the limiting case, not a non-theistic religion.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE - 6 MODELS

All six questions are original practice prompts rather than PYQs. Their models are independent examiner-oriented illustrations, not official answers.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Distinguish non-theism, atheism, agnosticism and religious naturalism. Why do these distinctions matter in the philosophy of religion?

Demand decoding: Define four positions by the different questions they answer, use examples, expose common confections, and explain the analytical value of the distinctions.

Model answer (about 320 words):

Non-theism, atheism, agnosticism and religious naturalism are not interchangeable because they concern different relations among God, knowledge and religious practice.

Non-theism describes a religious structure in which a creator or supreme saviour is not necessary. Buddhism explains suffering through dependent origination and ends it through the Eightfold Path; Jainism relies on *jīva*, karma and vows; Mīmāṃsā secures authority and ritual efficacy through the *apauruṣeya* Veda and *apūrva*. Non-theism therefore concerns the role, not necessarily the total non-existence, of divine beings.

Atheism denies or lacks belief in God. It need not generate religion. Cārvāka rejects God together with soul, karma, afterlife and liberation, and is consequently a critique of religious ontology rather than a religion without God. Dworkin's "religious atheism," however, shows that atheism can be combined with religious value when objective meaning and cosmic sublimity are retained.

Agnosticism concerns epistemic status. Weak agnosticism says God is not known; strong agnosticism says God is unknowable. An agnostic may suspend doctrinal assent while retaining ethical, contemplative or communal practice. This differs both from atheist denial and from Buddhism's positive non-theistic soteriology.

Religious naturalism makes an affirmative ontological proposal: nature, not a supernatural person, is the locus of ultimacy and reverence. Dewey's "religious" quality of experience and Goodenough's response to nature illustrate this route.

The objection is that these positions all remove orthodox creator-belief and therefore differ only verbally. The reply is that they generate different commitments: suspension is not denial; a naturalistic reinterpretation is not mere absence of belief; and a non-theistic path can retain karma, liberation and sacred practice.

The distinctions matter because they prevent two opposite errors-calling Buddhism simple atheism and calling every atheist outlook religious. A sound classification separately tests ontology, epistemic attitude, object of reverence, practice and soteriology.

Why this earns marks:

- Defines each term through a distinct philosophical question.

- Gives named Indian and Western examples.
- Uses Cārvāka to separate atheism from non-theistic religion.
- Includes an objection and a criterion-based verdict.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Does Cārvāka clarify the conceptual boundary of “religion without God”? Examine.

Demand decoding: Do not repeat the 2025 critique stem. Use Cārvāka comparatively to identify what Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā retain after removing God, then assess whether the boundary is defensible.

Model answer (about 330 words):

Cārvāka clarifies the boundary of religion without God precisely because it is not itself a religion without God. It removes not only a creator but the epistemic and soteriological framework through which non-theistic religions remain religious.

The strong Cārvāka position recognises perception alone as a secure *pramāṇa*. Inference depends on universal *vyāpti*, which cannot be perceived across all cases; an unnoticed *upādhi* may always condition the observed relation. Hence God, an immaterial soul, karma, rebirth, heaven and ritual potencies are rejected as suprasensible postulates. Consciousness is bodily, and *svabhāva* explains natural order without design.

By contrast, Buddhism removes a creator but retains Dharma, dependent origination, karma, the Saṅgha and nirvāṇa. Jainism retains jīvas, karmic matter, vows and siddhahood. Mīmāṃsā retains sacred Veda, injunction, ritual duty and *apūrva*. Their godlessness is therefore internal to a positive account of bondage, discipline and liberation. Cārvāka closes the route to that wider sacred order itself.

An objection follows: if religion is functionally defined through meaning and a way of life, Cārvāka’s this-worldly ethics might also count as religious. This makes the definition too broad. Hedonistic or naturalistic life-guidance alone does not supply ritual-experiential discipline, an ultimate sacred order or soteriology. Otherwise secular ethics and political ideology would also become religions.

Conversely, the boundary should not require belief in the supersensible as such, because religious naturalism locates ultimacy within nature. What is required is a disciplined and communal relation to ultimacy, practices of self-transformation and an existential or soteriological horizon. Cārvāka, as normally presented, lacks this integrated structure.

Thus Cārvāka performs a negative but valuable role. It demonstrates that “without God” does not mean “without any criterion”: Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā survive the loss of a creator because they retain sacred order and liberation, while Cārvāka’s more comprehensive negation normally crosses into non-religion.

Why this earns marks:

- Makes a direct boundary thesis instead of reproducing the PYQ answer.
- Uses *vyāpti* and *upādhi* only to support the comparative point.
- Specifies what three non-theistic traditions retain.
- Refines the criterion to accommodate naturalism without admitting every ethics.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Compare Jainism and Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā as two different strategies for sustaining religion without a creator God.

Demand decoding: Organise the answer comparatively, not as two unrelated notes. Explain ontology, authority, moral causation, practice, liberation, creator-critique and the strongest objection to each.

Model answer (about 515 words):

Jainism and Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā both sustain full religious systems without a creator, but they do so through contrasting strategies. Jainism builds a liberation-centred metaphysics of souls and karma; Mīmāṃsā builds a duty- and ritual-centred account of authorless authority and impersonal efficacy.

Jain ontology is pluralistic. Innumerable eternal jīvas possess consciousness but are bound by karmic matter attracted through passion and action. The religious problem is contamination and bondage; the solution is right faith, knowledge

and conduct, expressed through vows, restraint and ascetic purification. Liberation removes karmic obstruction and perfects the jīva into a siddha. Tīrthaṅkaras are liberated exemplars and teachers, not creators or dispensers of grace.

Jain anti-creator reasoning follows from this structure. The world and its basic constituents are beginningless. A creator with a body would be limited, while a bodiless agent faces the problem of acting on matter. A perfect being also lacks an unsatisfied motive to create, and attributing a flawed world to such a being creates moral difficulty. Cosmic and moral order are explained through the nature of substances and karma.

Mīmāṃsā begins not from soul-purification but from dharma disclosed in Vedic injunction. Jaimini defines dharma through *codanā*. The Veda is *apauruṣeya*: because it has no human or divine author, its authority does not depend on a speaker's reliability. Ritual acts are momentary whereas fruits may arise much later; *apūrva*, an unseen potency postulated through *arthāpatti*, links act and delayed result. Kumārila treats it as a potency associated with act or agent, while Prabhākara stresses *niyoga/kārya*, the enjoined ought-to-be-done.

Thus the schools replace different divine functions. Jainism replaces creation and judgement with beginningless substances and karmic matter; Mīmāṃsā replaces revelation with authorless language and providential reward with ritual law. Jain practice is ascetic-soteriological and directed toward freedom from karma. Mīmāṃsā practice is injunction- and sacrifice-centred, with classical concern for dharma and promised fruits.

Nyāya presses a common objection: unconscious karma or *apūrva* cannot select the correct result for the correct person at the correct time; an omniscient *karmādhyakṣa* is required. The non-theistic reply is that this models natural or moral regularity on deliberate administration and thereby begs the question. Law-like specificity does not entail a cosmic chooser. Against Mīmāṃsā, Nyāya also challenges eternal word-meaning relations; against Jainism, it can ask how non-conscious karmic matter tracks moral quality.

Jainism's strength is its integrated ethics and liberation, though the material character and moral precision of karma invite explanation. Mīmāṃsā's strength is showing that scripture, obligation and ritual fruit can be separated from God, though *apūrva* may look like an ad hoc unseen mechanism. Neither is covert theism: a siddha is an achieved perfect jīva, and *apūrva* is not a conscious judge.

Therefore both decisively weaken God's alleged necessity, but by different architectures-Jainism through a moral-soteriological cosmos and Mīmāṃsā through an autonomous sacred-linguistic and ritual order.

Why this earns marks:

- Sustains comparison across ontology, authority, causation, practice and goal.
- Uses jīva, karmic matter, siddha, *codanā*, *apauruṣeya* and *apūrva* precisely.
- Includes Nyāya's intelligent-allotment objection and a non-question-begging reply.
- Ends by identifying the distinct non-theistic architecture of each school.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Can religious fictionalism preserve sincere participation after metaphysical belief is withdrawn? Evaluate with reference to Indian graded-truth models.

Demand decoding: Define fictionalism and distinguish it from error theory and non-cognitivism. Analyse sincerity and motivation objections, then compare rather than equate it with Advaita and Buddhist two-truth frameworks.

Model answer (about 520 words):

Religious fictionalism holds that a person may participate rationally in religious discourse and practice without asserting its supernatural propositions as literally true. It attempts to preserve ritual, narrative, ethical formation and community after metaphysical belief is withdrawn. Its central difficulty is not logical possibility but sincerity.

The fictionalist grants that statements about God ordinarily possess truth-conditions, yet adopts them in a non-assertoric, practice-internal spirit. This differs from error theory, which concludes that false religious claims should be abandoned, and from non-cognitivism, which interprets religious language primarily as commitment, attitude or policy rather than failed description. Don Cupitt's non-realism and Robin Le Poidevin's explicit fictionalist route illustrate post-theistic participation.

The positive case appeals to familiar imaginative engagement. Readers can be emotionally transformed by fiction without believing its characters exist; participants in ritual drama can enact a narrative without deception. Religious stories may similarly organise attention, moral aspiration, grief and communal identity. Fictionalism also avoids

insincere intellectual assent: the participant openly declines literal assertion rather than pretending privately to believe.

Three objections remain. First, worship appears essentially addressed to someone. If the worshipper believes there is no recipient, prayer may become aesthetic performance. Second, the motivational power of sacrifice, hope and repentance may depend on truth-belief; practice could hollow out across generations. Third, believers themselves normally reject the fictionalist description, making it a revision of religion rather than an interpretation of existing faith.

The fictionalist replies that not every religious act is petition. Liturgy can shape character, express gratitude and sustain communal memory. Narrative efficacy does not always depend on literal belief, and transparent “as-if” participation need not involve self-deception. Nevertheless, this reply is partly empirical: whether durable motivation survives metaphysical withdrawal cannot be settled by conceptual analogy alone.

Indian graded-truth models sharpen the evaluation. In Advaita, *saguṇa* worship is genuinely valid and efficacious at the *vyāvahārika* level, though ultimately sublated in non-dual Brahman at the *pāramārthika* level. Sublation is not the same as knowingly treating worship as false fiction. Buddhism’s *saṃvṛti-paramārtha* distinction likewise permits committed conventional practice while denying ultimate substantial reference. These models preserve the practitioner’s sincerity through graded validity, whereas fictionalism begins from declined assertion.

An objection is that graded truth merely disguises fiction. The reply is that a conventionally true and efficacious claim has a recognised domain of validity; a fictive claim is adopted without assertion even in ordinary discourse. The logical structures therefore differ.

Religious fictionalism can preserve sincere participation if sincerity means transparent commitment to practice without counterfeit belief. It struggles if sincerity requires addressing a believed divine reality. Indian models do not solve fictionalism’s problem but reveal a stronger alternative: transform the level and meaning of truth rather than replace belief with pretence.

Why this earns marks:

- Defines fictionalism against two neighbouring theories.
- Gives the best imaginative-participation defence and all three major objections.
- Preserves the distinction between sublation, conventional truth and fiction.
- Reaches a conditional verdict rather than declaring fictionalism either dishonest or complete.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Compare the Buddhist, Jain, Mīmāṃsā and Sāṃkhya accounts of order and liberation without a creator. Do they reveal a common model of non-theistic religion?

Demand decoding: Give a structured four-way comparison, not parallel summaries. Identify each school’s replacement for creation, moral order and salvation; include cross-objections and finish by testing whether a common core survives doctrinal differences.

Model answer (about 710 words):

Buddhism, Jainism, Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā and classical Sāṃkhya jointly show that creator-belief is not necessary for a religious account of order and liberation. They do not, however, form one doctrine. Their commonality is architectural: each replaces divine agency with an impersonal order, disciplined practice and a transformative end.

Buddhism begins from *dukkha*, not cosmogenesis. Dependent origination explains events as conditionally arisen, avoiding a first creator. Karma connects intentional conduct with consequences, while the Four Noble Truths and Eightfold Path lead through ethics, meditation and wisdom to *nirvāṇa*. The Saṅgha provides institutional form. Devas, where admitted, remain conditioned and non-ultimate. The distinctive feature is *anātman*: liberation does not perfect an eternal soul but ends the causal conditions sustaining suffering.

Jainism accepts what Buddhism denies-innumerable enduring *jīvas*. These are bound by karmic matter through passion and activity. The cosmos and its constituent realities are beginningless; no creator initiates them. Right faith, knowledge and conduct, intensified through vows and ascetic restraint, stop karmic influx and remove accumulated bondage. Liberation reveals the *jīva*’s perfected state as *siddha*. Jain arguments add that an embodied creator would be limited, a bodiless creator’s action is obscure, and a perfect being lacks motive to create.

Mīmāṃsā shifts the centre from metaphysical liberation to sacred injunction and ritual performance. Dharma is known through Vedic *codanā*. Because the Veda is *apauruṣeya*, authority needs neither a human composer nor divine

revelation. A ritual act that perishes yet yields a later fruit generates *apūrva*, an unseen potency connecting performance and result. Kumārila stresses potency; Prabhākara stresses *niyoga/kārya*, the binding task disclosed by injunction. Deities named in sacrifice need not be autonomous agents who hear and grant; they function within the ritual grammar.

Sāṃkhya offers an ontological and epistemic route. Prakṛti, constituted by the three guṇas, evolves in proximity to plural puruṣas. The world-process exists for experience and release, but its apparent purposiveness does not require conscious manufacture. Bondage is misidentification of puruṣa with prakṛti's modifications; discriminative knowledge, *viveka-khyāti*, culminates in *kaivalya*. Classical Sāṃkhya should be distinguished from Yoga, whose Īśvara is a special puruṣa rather than straightforwardly the creator assumed in standard theism.

The comparison reveals three major differences. First, their ontologies range from Buddhist impermanence and no-self, through Jain soul pluralism, to Sāṃkhya dualism; Mīmāṃsā is primarily concerned with Vedic normativity. Second, moral causation is intentional and conditional in Buddhism, materially conceived in Jainism, ritually mediated through *apūrva* in Mīmāṃsā, and less central to Sāṃkhya's discrimination model. Third, liberation means nirvāṇa, purified siddhahood, ritual fruit or the fulfilment of dharma in classical Mīmāṃsā contexts, and isolation of puruṣa in Sāṃkhya.

Nyāya supplies a common objection. Unconscious conditions, karmic matter, *apūrva* or prakṛti cannot, it argues, produce purposive order and exactly fitted consequences without an intelligent maker and *karmādhyakṣa*. The objection is strongest against precise moral allotment. The non-theistic reply has two parts. Regularity need not resemble an artefact requiring a craftsman; appealing to intelligence may merely relocate the explanatory problem to divine motive, embodiment and responsibility. Further, liberation-centred explanation asks what sustains bondage and ends it, not who manufactured the total cosmos.

A second objection claims that impersonal Dharma, nirvāṇa, karma or prakṛti merely function as God under other names. Functional substitution, however, does not establish ontological identity. These principles do not create by will, issue commands as persons, forgive, enter covenants or bestow grace. Their impersonality changes religious life: petition and reciprocal devotion become less central, while discipline and knowledge become primary.

The four schools therefore share a common model only at a high level: a sacred or ultimate order, an account of the human predicament, a regulated path, community or lineage, and a transformative end. This model is strong enough to distinguish them from Cārvāka, which rejects the wider supersensible-soteriological order, but loose enough to respect their incompatible doctrines.

The graded verdict is that they establish a family of non-theistic religions, not one hidden theology. God's functions prove separable: causal order, normativity, moral consequence and liberation can be secured in different ways. What remains indispensable is not a creator but an intelligible relation among ultimate order, disciplined practice and release.

Why this earns marks:

- Gives equal doctrinal depth to all four schools.
- Compares mechanisms of order, bondage, practice and liberation explicitly.
- Includes Yoga's qualification and Nyāya's strongest common objection.
- Rejects the hidden-God claim without denying functional analogy.
- Derives a carefully limited common model and a Cārvāka boundary.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Can post-theistic value, reverence and ritual remain religious without collapsing into secular ethics? Discuss with reference to Nietzsche, religious naturalism and religious fictionalism.

Demand decoding: Build the modern debate from Nietzsche's problem of nihilism, then compare naturalist assertion with fictionalist non-assertion. Test both against the charge of being merely ethics or aesthetics, and use classical non-theistic religion as a control case.

Model answer (about 720 words):

Post-theistic thought asks a sharper question than classical non-theism: after a culture has lost belief in a personal God, can value, reverence and ritual remain genuinely religious, or do they become secular ethics with religious

vocabulary? Nietzsche diagnoses the problem; religious naturalism and fictionalism offer contrasting reconstructions.

Nietzsche's "death of God" is a cultural diagnosis of the collapse of the Christian-metaphysical horizon under the pressure of modern truthfulness and science. Because inherited European values depended on that horizon, its loss threatens nihilism. His genealogy interprets slave morality and the ascetic ideal through *ressentiment* and life-denial. Revaluation and self-overcoming are intended to create life-affirming values without divine command.

Nietzsche therefore demonstrates that removing God does not automatically leave a stable secular morality. The authority, genealogy and vitality of values become problems. Yet his positive response is not clearly a religion: it lacks a settled sacred order, communal liturgy and universal soteriology, and risks elitism or arbitrary power. Nietzsche is best treated as the bridge from theistic collapse to post-theistic value-creation, not as a straightforward founder of religion without God.

Religious naturalism offers a more affirmative reconstruction. It locates ultimacy within nature rather than a supernatural person. Awe, humility, gratitude and commitment respond to the natural world's depth and to objective value. John Dewey distinguishes institutional "religion" from "the religious," a quality of experience that unifies the self around inclusive ideal ends; his "God" names a relation between ideal and actual rather than a being. Ursula Goodenough treats nature's depth as capable of evoking a religious response. Ronald Dworkin's religious atheism retains objective intrinsic meaning in human life and the sublimity of the universe without personal theism.

Naturalism differs from ordinary secular ethics when these values are embedded in comprehensive ultimacy, communal symbol and transformative practice. Ethics asks what ought to be done; religious naturalism additionally cultivates a stance toward existence as a whole. Nevertheless, the objection is serious: awe before nature may be aesthetic emotion, and objective value may be moral realism, without worship, salvation or sacred authority. Calling them religious may stretch functional definition beyond usefulness.

The naturalist replies that religion has never been exhausted by petition to a supernatural person. Orientation to ultimacy, ritualised attention, community and self-transformation can be religious even when their object is immanent. This answer is strongest where actual practices and communities accompany the philosophy; otherwise it remains "religious" chiefly as an adjective for experience.

Religious fictionalism takes another route. It grants or suspects that supernatural claims are false or unwarranted but permits participation in a non-assertoric, fictive spirit. Don Cupitt's non-realism and Robin Le Poidevin's fictionalist proposal seek to retain narrative, liturgy and moral formation without metaphysical assent. Fictionalism differs from error theory, which abandons false discourse, and from non-cognitivism, which denies that the language primarily asserted descriptive propositions.

Its advantage is practical continuity: symbols and stories can shape emotion and conduct as literature does. Its liability is sincerity. Prayer seems directed to a believed hearer; sacrifice motivated by make-believe may become hollow; and believers reject the revisionary description. The fictionalist answers that transparent imaginative immersion is not deception and that ritual can express commitment rather than report ontology. Still, whether motivation survives over time is an unresolved empirical and existential issue.

Classical non-theistic traditions provide a control. Buddhism does not merely retain Christian forms after withdrawing belief. It possesses positive doctrines of dependent origination, karma, the Four Noble Truths, the Saṅgha and nirvāṇa. Jainism and Mīmāṃsā likewise contain objective sacred orders and soteriological disciplines. They show that religion without God can be thick. Modern naturalism and fictionalism are thinner because they must reconstruct ultimacy or participation after inherited metaphysics has weakened.

Indian graded-truth devices also expose fictionalism's weakness. Advaita regards saṁgha worship as efficacious at the *vyāvahārika* level and later sublated, not knowingly false. Buddhism's two truths permit serious conventional practice without ultimate substantial reference. Graded validity preserves sincerity more readily than explicit make-believe.

The verdict must therefore be conditional. Post-theistic value becomes more than secular ethics when it integrates a comprehensive ultimate orientation with communal, symbolic and transformative practice. Religious naturalism can meet this criterion, though often thinly. Fictionalism preserves religious forms but remains vulnerable on truth, motivation and sincerity. Nietzsche identifies why reconstruction is needed but does not by himself complete it. God can disappear while religious orientation survives; what cannot disappear without conceptual cost is every sacred horizon, lived discipline and transformation beyond ordinary moral rule-following.

Why this earns marks:

- Uses Nietzsche to frame the nihilism problem rather than misclassifying him as a simple atheist.
- Separates naturalist assertion, fictionalist non-assertion and secular ethics.
- Names Dewey, Goodenough, Dworkin, Cupitt and Le Poidevin with precise roles.
- Tests sincerity through Advaita and Buddhist graded-truth comparisons.
- Uses classical non-theistic religions as a control and gives a criterion-based final verdict.